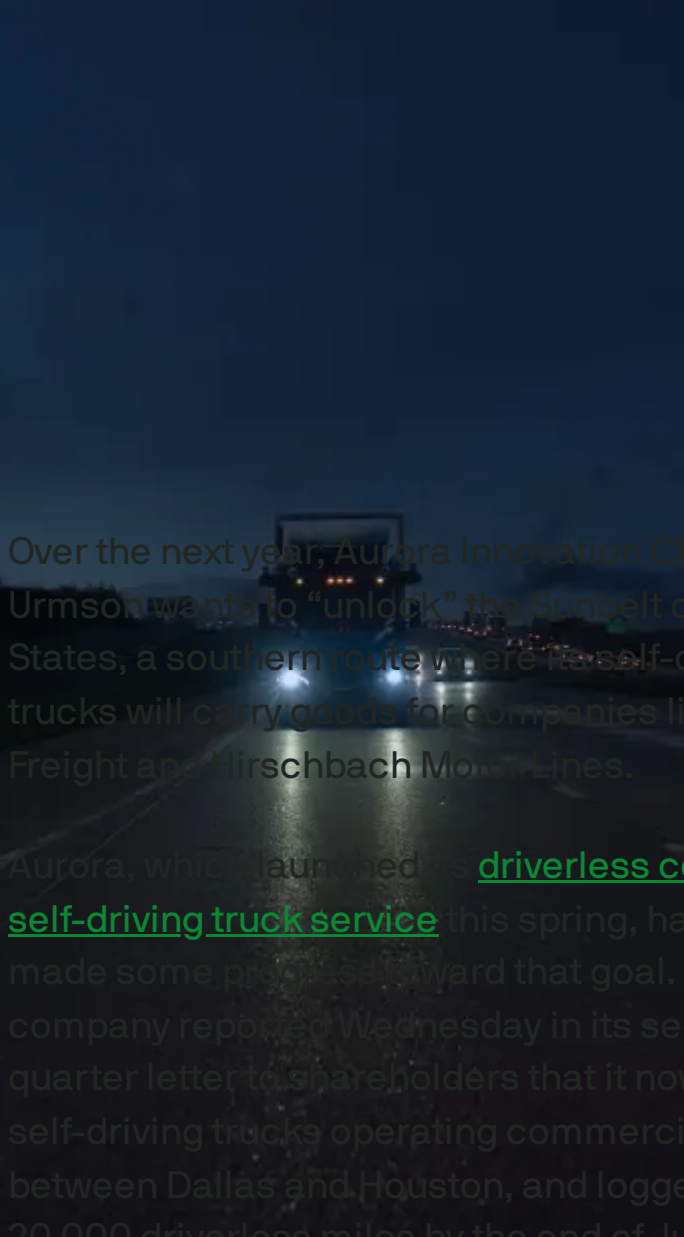


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Aurora's autonomous trucks are now driving at night. Its next big challenge is rain.



Over the next year, Aurora Innovation CEO Chris Urmson wants to “unlock” the Sunbelt of the United States, a southern route where its self-driving trucks will carry goods for companies like Uber Freight and Hirschbach Motor Lines.

Aurora, which launched its [driverless commercial self-driving truck service](#) this spring, has already made some progress toward that goal. The company reported Wednesday in its second-quarter letter to shareholders that it now has three self-driving trucks operating commercially between Dallas and Houston, and logged more than 20,000 driverless miles by the end of June. Its commercial self-driving trucks have a human “observer” in the cab, people who are not there to operate or intervene, according to the company.

Aurora has also opened a terminal in Phoenix, another physical sign of its Sunbelt trucking-route mission. Aurora is piloting autonomous trucking on a 15-hour route from its terminal in Fort Worth, Texas to Phoenix for customers, Hirschbach and Werner. The company’s terminals, which are located within one to five miles from the highway, require the driverless trucks to handle exits and surface streets.

But it’s the company’s ability to operate at night that helps it push into new territory. Aurora said Wednesday it has validated the ability for its driverless trucks to navigate highways and roads at

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night. This allows the trucks to travel longer distances — and importantly past the federally mandated service limitation for traditional human drivers. Truck drivers are allowed to drive up to 11 hours over a 14-hour period; and they can't do that day after day. Truck drivers are also required to take 10-hour breaks after completing a long-haul route.

“The value is really on longer lengths — so 600 miles is certainly a good range, where that is on the border of what's possible for people,” Urmson told TechCrunch in a recent interview, adding that ultimately he hopes Aurora trucks are carrying freight from Miami to California.

Urmson partially credits Aurora's proprietary, long-range lidar, which can detect objects in the dark more than 450 meters away, for its ability to operate at night. The lidar can identify pedestrians, vehicles, and debris up to 11-seconds sooner than a traditional driver, according to the company. Aurora has acquired two lidar companies since it was founded in 2017. The company bought [Blackmore](#), a Montana-based lidar startup, in May 2019 and OURS Technology in 2021.

Now, Urmson and the rest of Aurora's engineers are working to validate the driverless trucks' ability to operate in rain.

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“By the end of the year, we expect to be operating day, night, and in rain — if you can’t drive through the rain, ultimately, it’s hard to support these long operations because it’s raining somewhere,” he said.

Today, Aurora’s development fleet does operate in the rain and well enough that Urmson noted most would wonder why the company isn’t allowing its commercial trucks to do the same. Aurora has not completed the validation for that today, and “so we’re not willing to put that check mark next to it and let it go out there,” he noted.

Today, the company monitors weather on its one commercial route between Dallas and Houston. If adverse weather conditions like rain suddenly arise, those trucks are able to detect this and pull themselves off the road on their own where they will wait to be rescued, Urmson said.

“This year is really about building the capability toolbox so that the vehicles can drive where they need to,” he said in a nod to the company’s focus on validating driving at night and in the rain.

Next year, Aurora will focus on scaling its road network, in terms of distances and its fleet. Aurora plans to have “tens of driverless trucks” operating on public roads by the end of the year and “hundreds” by the end of 2026.

All of this, from the driverless trucks’ ability to function at night and in rain to opening more routes

and a with a larger fleet, will be critical if Aurora ever hopes to reach profitability.

The revenue-to-net income gap today is a large one. Aurora reported revenue of \$1 million in the second quarter and a net income loss of \$201 million, [according to its regulatory filing](#).

Topics: [Aurora Innovation](#) [self-driving trucks](#)

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Aurora launches commercial self-driving truck service in Texas

Rebecca Bellan — 6:55 AM PDT · May 1, 2025

Autonomous vehicle technology startup Aurora Innovation says it has successfully launched a self-driving truck service in Texas, making it the first company to deploy driverless, heavy-duty trucks for commercial use on public roads in the U.S.

The launch comes just as Aurora hits its deadline; in October, the company [delayed its planned 2024 debut](#) to April 2025. The debut also comes five months after rival Kodiak Robotics [delivered its first autonomous trucks](#) to a commercial customer for driverless operations in off-road environments.

Aurora says it began running freight this week between Dallas and Houston with its launch customers Hirschbach Motor Lines and Uber Freight, and that it has completed 1,200 miles in a single self-driving truck without a driver so far. The company plans to build up to “tens of self-driving trucks” and expand to El Paso and Phoenix by the end of 2025.

Aurora will also continue to haul “more than 100 loads of commercial freight” for customers every week with a fleet of more than 30 supervised

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autonomous trucks, according to a company spokesperson.

Aurora’s plan is to start its driverless trucking operations by owning, maintaining, and insuring its own trucks for customers. The company is working with its strategic partners Volvo Trucks and Paccar to develop self-driving trucks for high-volume manufacturing. Aurora expects its customers to buy those trucks directly from manufacturers starting in 2027 or earlier.

TechCrunch has reached out to learn whether the system has needed to implement a pullover maneuver or required remote human assistance, though CEO Chris Urmson said in a statement that the Aurora Driver “performed perfectly” during his inaugural trip.

Aurora’s commercial launch comes at a challenging time. Self-driving truck companies have long pitched the necessity of their technology due to labor shortages in long-haul trucking and an expected growth in freight shipping. Trump’s tariffs have changed that outlook, at least in the short term. According to an April report from commercial vehicle industry analysis firm [ACT Research](#), freight is expected to decrease in the U.S. this year as volumes and consumer spending decline.

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In response to how a freight pullback is expected to affect Aurora's business, an Aurora spokesperson pointed out that trucking faces other challenges, including skyrocketing operating costs and underutilized assets.

Aurora will be reporting its first-quarter results next week, which is when it will also share how it expects the current trade war to affect its future business. TechCrunch has reached out to learn more about how tariffs affect Aurora's business.

For now, Aurora will likely focus on continuing to prove its safety case without a driver, and work with state and federal legislators to adopt favorable policies to help it expand.

At the start of 2025, [Aurora brought a suit](#) against federal safety regulators after a court denied its request to be exempt from a safety requirement that involves placing warning triangles on the road when a truck needs to pull over on the highway — something that is difficult to do when there's no driver in the vehicle.

In order to remain in compliance with that rule and still deploy a fully driverless service, it would make sense for Aurora to have a human-driven car trail its trucks whenever they're in operation.

Rachel Chibidakis, an Aurora spokesperson, said the company did not require a driver to be in the vehicle.

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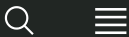
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AV company Aurora hires president ahead of commercial launch

Kirsten Korosec — 4:01 PM PST · January 30, 2023



Aurora Innovation said Monday it has hired Ossa Fisher as president as the autonomous vehicle company prepares to commercially launch its self-driving trucks business next year.

The company said Fisher, who was most recently president and chief operating officer of education tech company Istation, will be based in Dallas. Aurora is headquartered in Pittsburgh and has offices in San Francisco and Mountain View, but its self-driving truck testing and operations is in the Dallas area.

Aurora Innovation was founded in 2017 by Sterling Anderson, Drew Bagnell and Chris Urmson — three veterans of the nascent autonomous vehicle technology world who previously worked at Tesla, Uber and the Google self-driving project (now Waymo), respectively. Urmson is CEO, Anderson is chief product officer and Bagnell is chief scientist.

Fisher's experience building up and running a commercial business will balance out the more technical backgrounds of Aurora's three founders, according to a company spokesperson.

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The hiring comes about a year ahead of the company's planned commercial launch by the end of 2024.

Aurora does have a number of pilot programs with customers like [FedEx](#), Schneider and Uber Freight, all of which are "paying." However, Aurora doesn't recognize this as commercial revenue; instead, those pilot program payments are used to offset the company's R&D expenses. It does report "collaboration revenue," each quarter as part of its partnership with Toyota.

Aurora Innovation said in November it [had enough money](#) to continue to develop its autonomous vehicle technology until its commercial launch. The company closed the third quarter with about \$1.2 billion in cash and short-term investments.

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The company is expected to report its fourth-quarter earnings February 15.

Clarification: The collaboration revenue is from Toyota and not the pilot programs.

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Aurora and Continental
pass first major hurdle in
commercial self-driving
trucks deal



IMAGE CREDITS: AURORA

Aurora and automotive supplier Continental have wrapped up the first phase of a more than [\\$300 million project](#) to mass produce autonomous vehicle hardware for commercial self-driving trucks.

The two companies said Friday that the design and system architecture of an autonomous vehicle hardware kit is now complete. The blueprint for a secondary computer that can take over operation if a failure occurs — known as a fallback system — has also been finalized. The companies made the announcement ahead of a planned showcase at [CES 2024](#), the annual tech trade show that kicks off next week in Las Vegas.

While a seemingly small milestone in a [years-long and multimillion-dollar journey](#), it is a complicated and critical one. An array of hardware, including sensors such as radar, cameras and lidar, automated driving control units and high-performance computers, are used alongside software to allow a vehicle — in this case, driverless semi-trucks — to navigate roads without a human driver behind the wheel.

This means that Continental can now get to work on developing prototypes ahead of its plan to begin production in 2027. Continental will build initial versions of the hardware for testing at its new facility in New Braunfels, Texas over the next year. By 2026, the companies said that “validation” is expected to begin, a process that will include

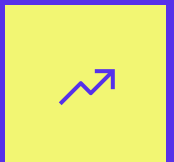
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integrating the hardware and software systems onto a fleet of trucks for testing. Aurora is also partnered with truck makers Paccar and Volvo Group.

The end goal is to mass produce an automotive-grade hardware system that can hold up to the cold, heat and other environmental conditions that long-haul trucks encounter every day. Importantly, the hardware system has to be reliable, easy to maintain and produced cheaply.

The companies have previously said the intent is to produce thousands of these systems.

[Aurora](#) co-founder and CEO Chris Urmson said finalizing the design of its future hardware is a meaningful step toward making the unit economics of the Aurora Driver compelling and building a business for the long-term. In other words, Urmson believes it's critical if the company hopes to become profitable.

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Aurora isn't waiting until 2027 or beyond to launch commercial operations, however. The company plans to launch up to 20 driverless Class 8 trucks — meaning no human behind the wheel — by the [end of 2024](#). Initially, these driverless trucks will carry freight between Dallas and Houston, a route the company has been using for testing.

While these first driverless trucks won't be equipped with the Aurora-Continental hardware kit, they are designed to automotive standards and to operate safely without a driver, according to Aurora spokesperson Rachel Chibidakis. Aurora will continue to update the hardware on this fleet over the next several years before switching to the kit designed to be manufactured at scale.

Correction: TechCrunch was given incorrect information on the number of driverless trucks that will initially launch at the end of year. The number has been corrected to “up to 20” driverless trucks.



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